Seranai

OpenFOS

Open Founder Operating System

Problem Validation

24 Skills + 2 Reference Modules
Organized by FOUNDRY Framework

Seranai · March 2026

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What Is This Skill?

Problem Validation is an AI powered tool that helps you answer the most important question any founder faces: Is this problem real enough, painful enough, and monetizable enough to build a company around?

It works as a conversation. You describe your startup idea in plain language, even a single sentence and the skill guide you through a structured validation process used by the top 1% of serial founders. No templates to fill out, no jargon to learn, no technical skills required.

> **THE CORE STATISTIC**
> **42% of startups fail because they build something nobody needs.** This skill exists to make sure you are not one of them.

By the end of one conversation (about 15 minutes), you will have a validated problem score, a clear Go/Pivot/Kill recommendation, and a concrete 2-week action plan to test your hypothesis in the real market.

Who Is This For?

This skill is designed for B2B founders at the earliest stage that is before you've built a product, before you've raised money, and ideally before you've written a single line of code. It is especially useful if:

- You have an idea and want to know if it's worth pursuing
- You've been thinking about a problem in your industry and want structured validation
- You're choosing between multiple ideas and need a framework to compare them
- You're a first-time founder who doesn't have access to experienced mentors
- You're in an emerging market and want to understand if your local problem has global potential

It works for founders anywhere in the world. Whether you're in San Francisco, Lagos, Bangalore, Dubai, São Paulo, or anywhere else, the validation framework adapts to your context.

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How to Get Started

Using this skill requires three things: access to Claude (claude.ai or the Claude app), the Problem Validation skill installed, and your idea described in your own words.

Step 1: Open Claude and Start a New Conversation

Go to claude.ai or open the Claude app. Start a new conversation. That's it.

Step 2: Describe Your Idea

Type your startup idea in plain language. You don't need a pitch deck, a business plan, or polished language. Just describe the problem you want to solve and who you think has this problem.

Examples of Great Starting Messages:

EXAMPLE 1 — Detailed

"I want to build an automated compliance monitoring tool for fintech startups in Southeast Asia. Right now they spend 20+ hours per month manually checking regulatory changes across 5 different countries, and most use spreadsheets to track it. I think they'd pay $500-1000/month for something that automates this."

EXAMPLE 2 — Brief

"I think there's a market for helping mid-size e-commerce companies manage their returns process. It's a mess for most of them."

EXAMPLE 3 — Minimal

"Invoice management for freelance designers."

All three of these will work. The more detail you provide, the sharper the initial analysis. But even a single sentence is enough to get started — the skill will ask follow-up questions to fill in the gaps.

Step 3: Follow the Conversation

The skill will guide you through four phases. You don't need to remember them or do anything special, just respond naturally to the questions it asks. The whole process takes about 15 minutes.

What Happens: The Four Phases

The skill walks you through four phases, each building on the last. Here's what to expect at each stage.

PHASE 1: INSTANT PROBLEM SNAPSHOT *Your idea gets an immediate intelligence briefing* • ~30 seconds	
What You Do	• Describe your idea (that's it — the skill does the rest)
What You Get	• Your problem restated in crisp founder language • A Hair-on-Fire Score (1-10) with justification • Vitamin vs. Painkiller assessment • 3-5 real competitors and alternatives (researched live) • 2 Green Flags + 2 Red Flags specific to your idea

WHY THIS MATTERS:
Most tools ask you 20 questions before giving you anything. This skill gives you immediate, specific intelligence within 30 seconds of your first message. That's the wow moment -you typed one sentence and got a structured market read back.

PHASE 2: SHARPENING QUESTIONS *Filling in the gaps to deepen the analysis* • ~3 minutes	
What You Do	• Answer 3-5 targeted questions about your customer, the problem evidence, and your unique advantage • It's okay to say "I don't know" - that's valuable data
What You Get	• A much sharper understanding of where your idea is strong and where it's weak

The questions are never generic. They are selected based on what's missing from your initial description. If you already provided detailed information about your customer, the skill won't ask you about your customer again - it will focus on the gaps.

PHASE 3: DEEP ANALYSIS *The full validation scorecard and verdict* • ~5 minutes to read	
What You Do	• Answer the sharpening questions from Phase 2
What You Get	• Problem Validation Scorecard (6 dimensions, each scored 1-10) • Evidence Map showing demand signals, competitive gaps, and counter-evidence • A clear GO / PIVOT / KILL recommendation with specific reasoning

PHASE 4: ACTION PLAN *Your 2-week validation sprint and next steps* • ~3 minutes to read	
What You Do	• Nothing additional - this is delivered automatically with Phase 3
What You Get	• Day-by-day 2-week validation sprint plan • 5 falsifiable hypotheses you can test immediately • Kill signals (when to stop) and success signals (when to accelerate) • A bridge to the next skill in the sequence (TAM-SAM-SOM)

Understanding Your Results

The Hair-on-Fire Score

This is your headline number. It measures how urgently your target customer needs this problem solved, on a scale of 1 to 10.

Score	Level	What It Means
8-10	**Hair on Fire**	Customers are actively spending money and time to solve this right now. They will pay for a better solution. This is the sweet spot.
5-7	**Moderate Pain**	Customers acknowledge the problem but live with workarounds. You'll need to prove your solution is significantly better than the status quo.
2-4	**Vitamin**	Nice to have, not need to have. Customers won't prioritize paying for this unless you reframe the problem or find a different customer.
1	**No Pain**	No evidence that this problem is real or painful enough to build a business around.

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The 6-Dimension Scorecard

The full scorecard evaluates your problem across six dimensions. Each is scored 1-10 with specific evidence.

Dimension	What It Measures
Problem Severity	How painful is this? Would a VP approve budget to fix it?
Problem Frequency	How often does the customer hit this problem? Daily pain = daily usage = high retention.
Existing Spend	Are people already paying to solve this? Existing spend is the strongest market signal.
Willingness to Pay	Would they pay for YOUR solution? At what price point?
Market Accessibility	Can you actually find and reach these customers efficiently?
Founder-Market Fit	Do YOU have an unfair advantage in solving this specific problem?

The Verdict: GO / PIVOT / KILL

GO (Overall Score 7+)
Strong validation across multiple dimensions. The problem is real, customers are paying to solve it, and you have a path to reach them. Proceed to market sizing with confidence. Your 2-week sprint should confirm what the data already suggests.

PIVOT (Overall Score 5-6.9)
The core insight has merit, but the current framing needs adjustment. The skill will tell you specifically what to pivot: a different customer segment, a different angle on the problem, or a different price point. Run the 2-week sprint to test the pivot.

KILL (Overall Score Below 5)
The evidence does not support this problem-solution hypothesis. This is not failure — killing a bad idea early is one of the best things a founder can do. You just saved yourself months of wasted effort. The skill will suggest where to redirect your energy based on what it learned about your strengths.

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Tips for Getting the Most Out of This Skill

Be honest, not optimistic. The skill can only be as honest as you are. If you sugarcoat your answers to the sharpening questions, you'll get a sugarcoated scorecard. The whole point is to find the truth before it's expensive.

"I don't know" is a valid answer. If you haven't talked to customers yet, say so. If you're not sure about pricing, say so. The skill treats gaps in knowledge as data points - they tell you where to focus your 2-week sprint.

Run it multiple times. Use this skill to compare different ideas side by side. Run your top 3 ideas through validation and compare the scorecards. The contrast is often more revealing than any single score.

Challenge a KILL verdict - but with evidence. If the skill recommends KILL and you disagree, that's okay. Founder conviction matters. But use the 2-week sprint plan to gather the specific evidence that would change the score. Don't just disagree - prove it.

Share the scorecard. Send your validation scorecard to a co-founder, advisor, or trusted peer. Ask them: "Does this match your read of the market?" External perspective catches blind spots the skill can't.

Actually run the 2-week sprint. The scorecard is not the deliverable. The sprint is. The scorecard tells you what to test. The sprint tells you if it's true. Don't skip this step.

Frequently Asked Questions

Do I need any technical skills to use this? No. You describe your idea in plain language and have a conversation. That's it.

How long does it take? About 15 minutes for the full conversation, depending on how much detail you provide.

Can I use this for B2C ideas? The skill is optimized for B2B, where the buying dynamics, pricing models, and validation methods are different from B2C. A B2C version is on the roadmap.

What if I disagree with the score? Good. That means you have conviction. Use the 2-week sprint plan to gather evidence that proves the score wrong. If you can't find that evidence, the score was probably right.

Can I run this for multiple ideas? Absolutely. Run each idea through its own conversation and compare the scorecards. This is one of the most powerful uses of the skill.

Is my data private? Your conversation is between you and Claude. The skill doesn't store or share your idea with anyone.

I'm in an emerging market. Will this work for me? Yes. The skill includes specific adjustments for founders building in or for emerging markets, including differences in payment infrastructure, market accessibility, and buying behavior.

The FOUNDRY Framework

FOUNDRY is the sequential journey framework that guides founders from initial idea through scale or exit. Each letter represents a stage, and each stage contains specific skills a founder needs to master.

Stage	Purpose	Skills
F – Foundation	Validate the idea. Confirm the problem is real, the market exists, and you know who to serve.	Skills 1–4
O – Outline	Design the business. Articulate value, map competition, model revenue, scope the MVP.	Skills 5–8
U – User	Acquire and understand customers. Discover needs, design GTM, set pricing, run experiments.	Skills 9–12
N – Nurture	Build relationships and traction. Craft the pitch, model financials, build the founder narrative.	Skills 13–15
D – Discipline	Execute and operate. Set OKRs, hire the team, handle legal and entity setup.	Skills 16–18
R – Results	Measure and iterate. Track KPIs, assess PMF, decide whether to pivot or persevere.	Skills 19–20
Y – Yield	Scale or exit. Confirm scaling readiness, plan liquidity events.	Skills 21–22

Cross-cutting skills (23–24) are not stage-specific and can be invoked at any point in the journey.

Reference modules (R1–R2) are shared evaluation lenses that multiple skills invoke. They are never used in isolation.